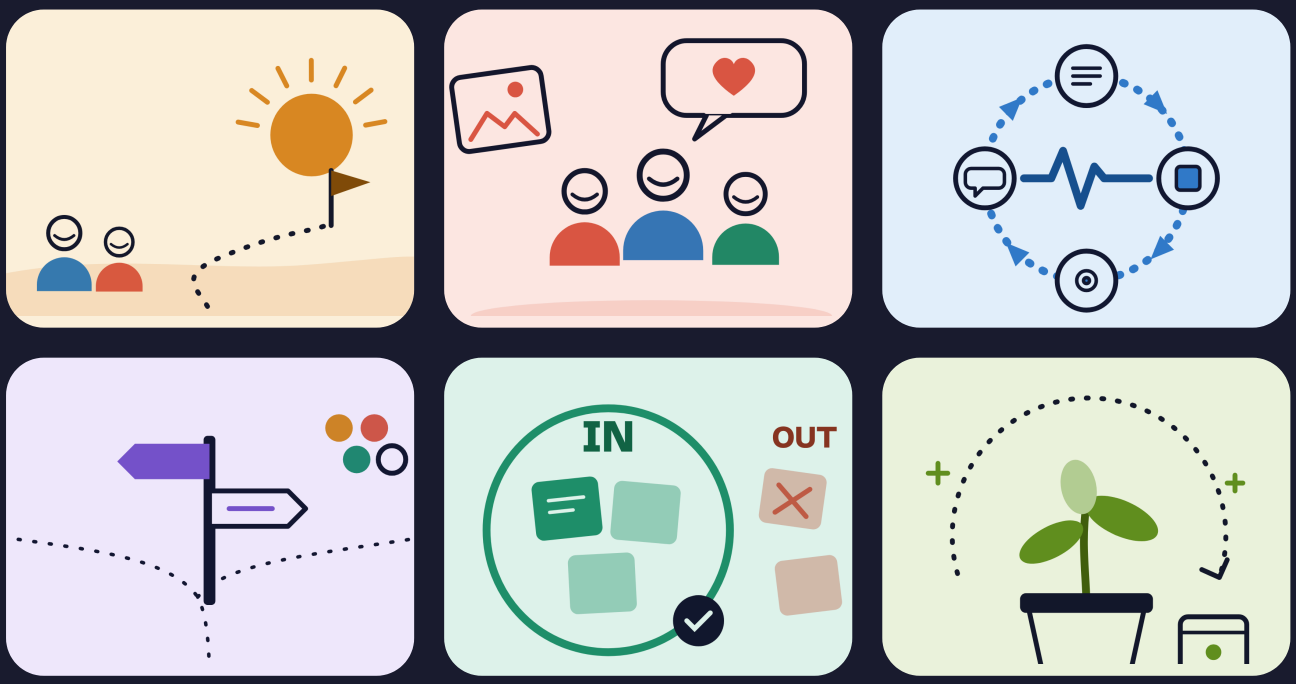
FORM YOUR TEAM · FACILITATION COURSE

Facilitator Guide

Session plans, what to say, and what to do when it gets tricky. One page per conversation, to take into the room.



Michael Heider

BEFORE YOU START

Facilitating your own team

The skills behind every conversation. Read this once; come back to it before each session.

Wear two hats

1. **Speak last**
   Ask the question, then wait. Add your view at the end, as one view among others.
2. **Name your hat**
   "Now I'm taking off my facilitator hat and speaking as your manager."
3. **Say what's open**
   "We decide this together" or "I decide, but I want your input". Be honest about which.
4. **Hand it over**
   If the topic is about you, your leadership or a conflict you're in, let someone else facilitate.

Prepare

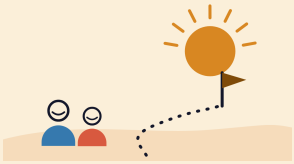
1. **Purpose**
   Finish the sentence: "After this session, we will have…"
2. **Invitation**
   Why you're doing this, in your own words. Short, human, no hidden agenda.
3. **Room**
   Wall space, big canvases, thick markers, chairs in a circle. Online: test the board first.
4. **Time**
   No laptops for email, no "first half only".

The core moves

1. **Open** · Check-in round · why we're here and what we'll have at the end · one or two ground rules
2. **Hold** · Write before talking · rounds so everyone speaks · keep time out loud · a "later" sheet
3. **Close** · Protect the last 10 minutes · read back · "anything you can't live with?" · who writes it up · check-out

Make it safe to be honest

- Start with low-risk questions and build up.
- Use silent writing and anonymous options.
- Your first reaction to criticism decides if there will be a second: "Thank you, tell me more."
- Name the silence: "What would someone who disagrees say?"
- Follow through, or people stop speaking up.



CONVERSATION 1

Why are we here?

On the canvas: A purpose statement ("We exist to… for… by…") and a picture of success in three years.

Signs your team needs it

1. People describe the team's job very differently
2. The team says yes to almost everything
3. New people take months to understand what the team is for
4. Talk is about tasks, never about who it's for

Exercise

Explain it to a friend

The full steps are on the exercise canvas and in the workbook.

Would we say this to a friend? Does it help us say no to something?

Session plan: Why are we here? · 75 min · 09:00–10:15

09:00 5 min	**Check-in round**	*"In one word: how do you arrive today?"*
09:05 5 min	**Why we're here, and what we'll have at the end**	*"By the end, we'll have a first version of our purpose, in our own words."*
09:10 10 min	**Explain it to a friend, in pairs (2 × 4 min)**	*"Explain our team the way you would to a good friend at dinner. Listeners: only write down phrases that sound clear and human."*
09:20 15 min	**Post-its on the canvas, cluster, circle the strongest words**	*"Which words keep coming back? Which ones would you be proud to say?"*
09:35 15 min	**Draft "We exist to… for… by…"**	*"Good enough for now. We can polish the words later."*
09:50 15 min	**In three years' time…, then dot vote**	*"Vote for the version that feels true, not just ambitious."*
10:05 10 min	**Read back, agree next steps, check-out**	*"What do you take with you from today?"*

CONVERSATION 1 · WHY ARE WE HERE?

When it gets tricky

What often happens in this conversation, and what you can say.

MOMENT 1

“Our purpose is just what our boss tells us.”

WHAT YOU CAN DO

“You’re right that some of it is given. Within that, what do we want to be known for?”

MOMENT 2

Endless wordsmithing

WHAT YOU CAN DO

“We have the meaning. The words can be polished later.” Ask two volunteers to bring back two versions.

MOMENT 3

A real disagreement about what the team is for

WHAT YOU CAN DO

Don’t smooth it over. Write both versions down: “What would be different in our work if it were one or the other?”

Your notes for this session



CONVERSATION 2

Who are we?

On the canvas: The team's strengths, what it wants to develop, and how each person works at their best.

Signs your team needs it

1. New people have joined
2. People rarely ask each other for help
3. Repeated misunderstandings about communication
4. People know titles, not strengths

Exercise

Personal user manual

The full steps are on the exercise canvas and in the workbook.

Repeat this conversation every time someone joins or leaves.

Session plan: Who are we? · 70 min · 09:00–10:10

09:00	5 min	**Check-in round** *"Something people here might not know about you."*
09:05	5 min	**Share your own personal user manual first** *"I'll go first, and I'll be honest about the pressure one."*
09:10	10 min	**Everyone writes their manual, in silence** *"One post-it per prompt. Share what you're comfortable with."*
09:20	20 min	**Pairs: talk it through, one question each** *"Ask one question to understand, not to challenge."*
09:40	15 min	**Each pair shares one surprising or useful insight** *"Not the whole manual. Just one thing you learned."*
09:55	5 min	**Agree where the manuals live, and how new joiners add theirs**
10:00	10 min	**Check-out** *"What will you do differently with someone in this room?"*

CONVERSATION 2 · WHO ARE WE?

When it gets tricky

What often happens in this conversation, and what you can say.

MOMENT 1

Someone doesn't want to share

WHAT YOU CAN DO

Always optional: "Share what you're comfortable with."

MOMENT 2

Answers stay on the surface

WHAT YOU CAN DO

"And when it really matters, what helps you do your best work?" Or share a deeper answer yourself.

MOMENT 3

Something comes up that hurts

WHAT YOU CAN DO

Acknowledge it: "That sounds important. Let's come back to it in the decisions conversation." Then do.

Your notes for this session



CONVERSATION 3

How do we work?

On the canvas: When and how we plan, make and review, and the meetings and habits we drop.

Signs your team needs it

1. Full calendar, unclear priorities
2. "We should have talked about this earlier"
3. Deep work happens in the evenings
4. Nobody remembers the last look back

Exercise

Draw your team's loop

The full steps are on the exercise canvas and in the workbook.

For every meeting you drop: "Who might miss something, and how will they hear about it now?"

Session plan: How do we work? · 75 min · 09:00–10:15

09:00	5 min	**Check-in round** *"One meeting you'd miss, and one you wouldn't."*
09:05	5 min	**Draw the loop: plan, make, review** *"Every team goes through this loop, whether they plan it or not."*
09:10	10 min	**Everyone writes the meetings and habits we have today** *"One per post-it. Include the informal ones."*
09:20	10 min	**Place them on the loop, then look at the pattern** *"What do you notice?"*
09:30	15 min	**Keep, change, combine or remove: one by one, quickly** *"What problem was this meeting solving?"*
09:45	20 min	**Agree when and how we plan, make and review** *"Let's try this for one cycle, then look at it again."*
10:05	10 min	**Read back, put the review in the calendar, check-out**

When it gets tricky

What often happens in this conversation, and what you can say.

MOMENT 1

The meeting nobody likes but nobody can drop

WHAT YOU CAN DO

"How can we make it cost us less?" Often it can become a weekly written update.

MOMENT 2

Different people need different rhythms

WHAT YOU CAN DO

Agree a minimum shared rhythm and let the rest be flexible.

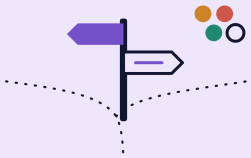
MOMENT 3

The review doesn't happen

WHAT YOU CAN DO

Put it in the calendar right away, keep it short, look at real work, not slides.

Your notes for this session



CONVERSATION 4

How do we make decisions?

On the canvas: The decisions that come up often: who decides, who is asked, who is told, and how.

Signs your team needs it

1. The same topic keeps coming back
2. "Who decided this?" more often than "why?"
3. Everything goes up to the manager
4. Good discussions, no clear decision

Exercise

Choose how to decide

The full steps are on the exercise canvas and in the workbook.

Reopen a decision only with new information: "What new information do we have?"

Session plan: How do we make decisions? · 75 min · 09:00–10:15

09:00	5 min	**Check-in round** *"A decision this month that went well, and why."*
09:05	10 min	**Everyone writes decisions that come up again and again** *"One per post-it. Small ones count too."*
09:15	10 min	**Cluster and pick one that causes friction today**
09:25	15 min	**Read the twelve ways to decide together** *"Does this need narrowing, speed, everyone on board, or a final say?"*
09:40	20 min	**Choose: who decides, who is asked, who is told, and how** *"Could someone new read this and know what to do?"*
10:00	5 min	**Agree to try it the next few times**
10:05	10 min	**Read back and check-out**

When it gets tricky

What often happens in this conversation, and what you can say.

MOMENT 1

“But you’re the manager, you decide.”

WHAT YOU CAN DO

Say which decisions you keep and which you hand over. Then really hand them over.

MOMENT 2

Everyone wants consensus for everything

WHAT YOU CAN DO

Offer consent: “Is this good enough for now, and safe enough to try?”

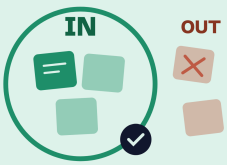
MOMENT 3

The decision isn’t yours to give

WHAT YOU CAN DO

Write it on the canvas with its real owner, so the team sees where its influence ends.

Your notes for this session



CONVERSATION 5

How do we want to be together?

On the canvas: A short team contract: five to eight behaviours that are IN, and the ones that are OUT.

Signs your team needs it

1. Tension that nobody names
2. People complain to you, not to each other
3. A behaviour bothers several people, but everyone tolerates it
4. New people keep stepping on unwritten rules

Exercise

The two-circle team contract

The full steps are on the exercise canvas and in the workbook.

Could you tell whether someone is doing it? If not, rewrite it.

Session plan: How do we want to be together? · 90 min · 09:00–10:30

09:00	5 min	**Check-in round** *"A moment this team was at its best."*
09:05	5 min	**Draw two circles: IN and OUT**
09:10	15 min	**IN: behaviours we want to practise and protect** *"What were people doing when we were at our best? Start with a verb."*
09:25	15 min	**OUT: behaviours that undermine trust, inclusion or good work** *"Behaviours, not people."*
09:40	20 min	**Rewrite until you could see it happen** *"Could you tell if someone is doing this?"*
10:00	10 min	**Dot vote: keep the five to eight that matter most**
10:10	10 min	**Can everyone live with this? What do we do when it's broken?**
10:20	10 min	**Check-out**

When it gets tricky

What often happens in this conversation, and what you can say.

MOMENT 1

A post-it is clearly about one person

WHAT YOU CAN DO

Keep the focus on the behaviour: “Do we agree it belongs in OUT?” Follow up privately if needed.

MOMENT 2

The contract is too polite

WHAT YOU CAN DO

“What’s one behaviour that happens here that we haven’t written down?” Then silent time, or anonymous post-its.

MOMENT 3

People disagree about a behaviour

WHAT YOU CAN DO

Talk it through. If you can’t agree, write down what you can: “Nobody is expected to answer after six.”

Your notes for this session



CONVERSATION 6

How do we learn and reform?

On the canvas: What to keep, what to change, one or two small experiments, and what should bring you back to the canvas.

Signs your team needs it

1. Something changed: a new person, leader or strategy
2. Agreements are quietly ignored
3. The team feels tired or stuck
4. Six months since you looked at the canvas

Exercise

Keep / Change / Try

The full steps are on the exercise canvas and in the workbook.

An experiment nobody looks at again is just a wish. Agree who keeps an eye on it, and when.

Session plan: How do we learn and reform? · 60 min · 09:00–10:00

09:00	5 min	**Check-in round** *"What's changed for you since we last talked about the team?"*
09:05	5 min	**Walk past the canvas, if you have one** *"Is this still true?"*
09:10	10 min	**Keep: write, then a round** *"What about this team should we protect?"*
09:20	10 min	**Change: write, then a round** *"What is no longer helping us?"*
09:30	15 min	**Try: choose one or two small experiments** *"What exactly will we do, from when, and who keeps an eye on it?"*
09:45	5 min	**What should make us sit down with the canvas again?**
09:50	10 min	**Read back and check-out**

When it gets tricky

What often happens in this conversation, and what you can say.

MOMENT 1

Change turns into complaining

WHAT YOU CAN DO

"What part of this is within our control?" Then move to Try sooner.

MOMENT 2

The same Change items come back

WHAT YOU CAN DO

"This is the third time we've written this. What's really stopping us?"

MOMENT 3

Big changes nobody chose

WHAT YOU CAN DO

Make room first: "What are we losing, and what do we want to take with us?"

Your notes for this session

WHAT GOOD LOOKS LIKE

A finished canvas

Example: a seven-person customer support team (invented, for illustration). Yours will look different. Notice how concrete it is: names, numbers and behaviours someone could actually see.

1 Why are we here?

"We exist to get customers back to work fast, for the people who use our product every day, by solving problems on the first contact and telling product what keeps breaking."

In three years: half as many repeat tickets; product asks us before they ship.

2 Who are we?

Strengths: calm on the phone (Sara, Jonas), spotting patterns (Mei), writing clear help articles (Ali).

Want to grow: data skills, saying no to side requests.

From the user manuals: "Message me, don't call before 10." "Ask me twice if it's urgent."

3 How do we work?

Monday 15 min: plan the week and who covers the queue.

Thursday 30 min: look at the top five repeat problems.

Monthly: one hour look back. Dropped: the Friday status meeting (now a written update).

4 How do we make decisions?

Refunds under €200: whoever has the ticket decides, and tells the team.

Changes to help articles: the writer decides after asking one colleague.

Shift plan: the team agrees by consent. Hiring: the manager decides after asking everyone.

5 How do we want to be together?

IN: we ask for help after 20 minutes stuck · we say it in the room, not after · we hand over tickets with a two-line note.

OUT: answering the team chat after 18:00 · "that's not my ticket".

6 How do we learn and reform?

Keep: the Thursday pattern half hour. Change: Monday runs long.

Try for one month: a shared "stuck" emoji in the chat. Mei checks in at the next look back.

Come back to the canvas when someone joins or the product changes a lot.

REMOTE TEAMS

Running it online or hybrid

The six conversations work online. They need more structure than in a room, because it's easier to hide behind a screen.

Six rules for online sessions

1. **One person, one screen**
   In hybrid sessions everyone joins from their own laptop, even people in the same room. Otherwise the room talks and the screens listen.
2. **One board, tested**
   Put the board link in the invitation. Open with a two-minute tour: where to write, how to add a note, where the timer is.
3. **Get a co-host**
   Someone else runs breakout rooms, the timer and the board, so you can watch the people.
4. **Shorter blocks**
   Keep it to 75–90 minutes. A two-hour session works better as two shorter ones on different days.
5. **Write first, then talk**
   Silent writing on digital notes, with a visible timer. Each person gets their own colour.
6. **Make the rounds explicit**
   Paste the speaking order in the chat, and call names. Silence online is harder to read than in a room.

Each exercise, online

- **Explain it to a friend** · Pairs in breakout rooms. The listener types phrases straight onto the board.
- **Personal user manual** · Everyone fills in their own frame before the session. Share in rounds.
- **Draw your team's loop** · One shared timeline on the board. Everyone adds their own meetings first.
- **Choose how to decide** · A table on the board, one row per decision. Dot-vote which rows to discuss.
- **Two-circle team contract** · Two circles on the board. Anonymous notes work well online.
- **Keep / Change / Try** · Three columns and a timer. Vote with dots on which Try to start.

AFTER THE SESSIONS

Keep it alive

A typical series

1. **Week 1** · Why are we here?
2. **Week 2–3** · Who are we?
3. **Week 5** · How do we work?
4. **Week 7** · How do we make decisions?
5. **Week 9** · How do we want to be together?
6. **After ~3 months** · How do we learn and reform?

Start with the conversation your team needs most. Put the next date in the calendar before people leave the room.

Bring in an outside facilitator when

1. The topic is about you
2. Trust is low
3. The stakes are high
4. You want to take part fully

A colleague from another team can do it too. Or swap: you facilitate theirs, they facilitate yours.

Follow-through

1. **Write it up within a day**
   Just the canvas and a short list of agreements. Put it where people see it.
2. **Use it**
   Check the decision rules, walk new joiners through it, point to the contract.
3. **Follow up on actions**
   On your normal task list. Two minutes in the next team meeting: "How are we doing with what we agreed?"
4. **Notice what changes**
   "What's different since we had this conversation?" Celebrate the small things.